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JERUSALEM INTERNATIONAL FELLOWS

Dear <<First Name>>,

The Fellows are back home. Here's one beautiful reflection from Mexican choreographer Claudia Lavista:

Dear Elise.

I'm finally at the aeroport heading home...

Mixed feelings. But mostly, I feel deeply grateful to you, this program and for this amazing experience...

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For your belief in the artist and what art can do.

I'm going back home full of new visions and ideas, and a better understanding of Israeli/Palestinian culture!

But mainly I'm leaving with new friends, with a new community of wonderful people that I can now call colleagues.

So, this is now a place for me to come back and have joy... that's priceless!!!

Mucho amor

Claudia

Also, we are thrilled to share the following articles that appeared last weekend in Ha'aretz and the Jerusalem Post. There are more articles that were published early in the residency which you can read [here](#).

<https://www.haaretz.com/life/.premium-this-woman-is-turning-jerusalem-into-an-open-air-art-studio-1.10809633>

<https://www.jpost.com/israel-news/culture/article-707178>

If you have difficulty accessing the Ha'aretz story, I have provided a copy of it below.

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Jerusalem Into an Open-air Art Studio

Elise Bernhardt is on a mission: for visiting artists to fall in love with Jerusalem the way she did – warts and all

[Judy Maltz](#)

May. 19, 2022

The visiting artists were wondering where their studios in Jerusalem would be located. Elise Bernhardt, the founder and director of their program, had some surprising news. “There are no studios,” she told them. “The city will be your studio.”

Ten weeks later, the participants in this first-of-its-kind cultural program – four women who hail from different countries – unanimously agree: It was a brilliant idea.

“This is not about sitting in a studio,” says Bernhardt, the initiator of the Jerusalem International Fellows program. “This is about getting out there, creating networks and engaging with locals.”

Their studio – that is, [Jerusalem](#) – was unable to provide these women with the peace and quiet artists so often seek. Quite the opposite, in fact. During their stay, tensions reached a boiling point, threatening to erupt into an all-out war. Clashes between Israeli police and Palestinians spread from the [Temple Mount](#) to Damascus Gate, and from there to other parts of the city. Tensions escalated yet again over the weekend, during the funeral of prominent Al-Jazeera journalist Shireen Abu-Akleh, from which scenes of police beating mourners [were broadcast throughout the world](#).

This, then, was the background noise these women heard over the past two-and-a-half months as they went about their creative endeavors.

Sophia Borges, a visual artist from Brazil, is being hosted by the Idbaa School of the Arts in [Sheikh Jarrah](#), an East Jerusalem neighborhood that has been a major focus of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict; Vibha Galhotra, a conceptual

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border of the eastern and western parts of the city; Claudia Lavista, a choreographer and dancer from Mexico, is being hosted by the c.a.t.a.m.o.n. dance group in West Jerusalem; and Anna Lublina, an interdisciplinary performer from the United States, is being hosted by the Bloomfield Science Museum, also in the western part of the city. For all four women selected for this pilot program, this has been a first trip to Jerusalem.

The Jerusalem International Fellows program is the brainchild of Bernhardt, the former director of the New York-based Foundation for Jewish Culture. It started out several years ago as the American Academy in Jerusalem, a program that brought American artists and performers to the Israeli capital, where they were hosted by Jewish organizations based in the western part of the city.

Bernhardt decided to switch it up a bit this year. Instead of focusing exclusively on Americans, this year's cohort includes representatives from other countries as well. But perhaps the most significant change is that this year the hosting organizations are on both the western, largely Jewish and eastern, largely Arab sides of the city.

In the 1980s, Bernhardt founded Dancing in the Streets, an organization that produced free public dance performances. Her experiences there, she says, inspired the concept behind the latest iteration of the Jerusalem fellows program.

"We worked in places where there was a lot of conflict, mainly racial conflict, and one of our goals was to get people to cross borders," she says. "It was based on the same that artists performers need to be out there, rather than confined in studios."

And why Jerusalem? "I am madly in love with this city," she says. "My objective is for these artists to fall in love with it as well – warts and all."

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Sofia with twin students and their mom at Ibdad School of the Arts.

It is clear that the Fellows have acquired a deep sense of the City. Some of what they said at the Interview that wasn't included in the Ha'aretz article is [here](#). We also have posted [videos](#) that include more extensive comments.

Anna: "I was surprised to see how un-unified is this place, in a good way...There was space for me to be a diasporic Jew."

Sofia: "We learned that one of the meanings of Jerusalem is Peace. There's no better place to be called peace than the one that promotes conflict."

Claudia: "Jerusalem is a creature. Like a small version of the shifting of tectonic plates..."

Vibha: " I was concerned when I got here - where is my studio, where will I work? **I discovered that the city was my studio...**" (Yes that was her quote in the Ha'aretz piece.)

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Claudia teaching a Master Class at Jerusalem Academy of Music and Dance.

Here are some earlier articles from the residency:

<https://heraldodemexico.com.mx/cultura/2022/4/8/ofrenda-dancistica-mario-lavista-con-video-obra-hecha-por-su-hija-claudia-lavista-394292.html>

<https://www.sundayguardianlive.com/culture/indian-artist-vibha-galhotra-makes-waves-jerusalem>

<https://themedialine.org/life-lines/weeks-of-terror-raids-and-clashes-did-not-deter-east-and-west-from-breaking-the-fast-together/>

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from left: Anna, her partner and collaborator Gre, Vibha, and Maya Pennington, singer in Anna's work at Bloomfield Science Museum. They're at the coolest music venue in Jerusalem, Mazkeka.

We will continue to upload photos, videos, and reflections from our Fellows. You can also enjoy photos and videos on our Instagram [@jerusaleminternationalfellows](#).

We welcome your questions and comments and look forward to telling and showing you more about our Fellows as their connections unfold. Feel free to [email me](#).

Thanks to all of you who have helped realize this program which will continue to bear fruit.

Be well.

Elise

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